

ENG 111: Public Speaking

- Lecture 3: Verbal Messages
- Fall 2026 | Class 3 | Chapter 4
- Focus: How words create meaning and influence communication

Today's Class

- Recap — 5 min
- Warm-up — 10 min
- Verbal messages and meaning — 20 min
- Word choice and clarity — 15 min
- Pair work — 15 min
- Group work — 20 min
- Wrap-up — 5 min

Warm-Up: Same Words, Different Meaning

- Read: “That’s interesting.”
- It may show genuine interest, surprise, disagreement, politeness, or sarcasm.
- PAIR DISCUSSION: How can the same words communicate different meanings? Give one example.

Example: Context Changes Meaning

- Friend: “How was your exam?” → “Fine” may mean satisfactory.
- After an argument: “Fine.” may communicate anger or disappointment.
- Key idea: Context and delivery influence meaning.

What Are Verbal Messages?

- Verbal messages use words to share information, express feelings, build relationships, and influence others.
- Public speakers choose words carefully because language affects audience understanding.

Words Are Symbols

- Words represent people, objects, ideas, and experiences.
- Example: book | বই | 本
- GROUP QUESTION: What does this tell us about the relationship between words and meaning?

Meaning Is Not Only in the Word

- People bring experiences and knowledge to communication.
- Example: “Home” may suggest comfort to one person but loneliness to another.
- PAIR WORK: Discuss how two people might understand success, freedom, family, education, or respect differently.

Denotative Meaning

- The literal or dictionary meaning of a word.
- Example: “Snake” = a long, legless reptile.
- DISCUSS: Why is precision important when explaining facts or giving instructions?

Connotative Meaning

- Feelings and associations connected to a word.
- Example: “Home” may suggest warmth, safety, or belonging.
- Compare “childlike” and “childish.”
- PAIR DISCUSSION: How do their associations differ?

Concrete and Abstract Words

- Concrete: microphone, classroom, rain, bicycle.
- Abstract: freedom, justice, happiness, success.
- TIP: Use concrete examples to make abstract ideas easier for audiences to understand.

Activity: Make It More Concrete

- Abstract: “Education is important.”
- More concrete: “Education can help students develop knowledge, professional skills, and opportunities for future employment.”
- PAIR TASK: Improve: “Technology has changed our lives.”

Clear or Vague?

- Vague: “Many students have problems.”
- Clearer: “Some first-year students report difficulty managing coursework, presentations, and deadlines.”
- Ask: What exactly do I mean? Can I give an example?

Ambiguous Language

- A statement can have more than one meaning.
- Example: “I saw her duck.”
- Did she lower her head, or did you see her pet duck?
- PAIR WORK: Create one ambiguous sentence, then rewrite it clearly.

Inclusive and Respectful Language

- Consider how language affects different audiences.
- Avoid unnecessary stereotypes and disrespectful labels.
- Describe people and situations accurately.
- DISCUSS: Why can careless language damage a speaker's credibility?

Powerful Word Choice

- Plain: “Plastic pollution is a problem.”
- More vivid: “Plastic waste can remain in the environment for generations, affecting rivers, oceans, and wildlife.”
- DISCUSS: Which creates a clearer picture, and why?

PAIR WORK 1: Say It Better

- Rewrite for a formal presentation:
 1. “The thing is really bad.”
 2. “Everybody knows this is true.”
 3. “Students have many issues.”
- Make each precise, credible, and audience-appropriate.

PAIR WORK 2: Audience Adaptation

- Message: “Students should develop better time-management skills.”
- Prepare Version A for first-year students.
- Prepare Version B for parents at university orientation.
- Change vocabulary, examples, and tone. Explain why.

GROUP ACTIVITY: Communication Detectives

- Groups of 4–5. Analyze one message:
- “They are not doing well.”
- “The event was successful.”
- “We need to improve communication.”
- Identify what is unclear, ask questions, and rewrite it precisely.

Group Example

- Original: “We need to improve communication.”
- Questions: Between whom? What problem exists? What should change?
- Possible revision: “The student club should provide members with clear meeting schedules and deadlines through one official communication channel.”

GROUP CHALLENGE: Mini Message

- Choose: mental health awareness, responsible social media use, environmental protection, academic integrity, or healthy campus life.
- Prepare a 45-second message using clear language, one concrete example, audience awareness, and one memorable phrase.

Share and Feedback

- Listen for: clear language, appropriate vocabulary, concrete examples, audience awareness, and memorable wording.
- After each group: give one positive comment and one constructive suggestion.

Key Takeaways

- Words are symbols.
- Meaning is influenced by people and context.
- Words have denotative and connotative meanings.
- Concrete language makes ideas clearer.
- Avoid vague and ambiguous language.
- Adapt language to your audience.

Exit Ticket

- 1. Write one word whose meaning can change depending on context.
- 2. Write one vague statement and improve it.
- 3. Name one thing you will consider when choosing words for a speech.

Next Class

- Topic: Nonverbal Messages
- Observe one real-life interaction before class.
- Notice facial expressions, eye contact, posture, gestures, and tone.
- What was communicated without words?